

Understanding existing and new users' perceptions, behaviors, and priorities

Across age groups and FT vs. non-FT users

UR Team Nov '25 

Shira Kedem

What was the **purpose** of this research project?

We aimed to evaluate how FT and non-FT users edit and perceive photo editing today, identifying similarities & differences across age groups.

We explored:

- 1) Perceptions of “Good” Images: Which elements create a desirable image, vibe, or aesthetic for them?
- 2) Editing Behaviors: Which image aspects (e.g., face, body, lighting, filters) and types of edits are most commonly used?
- 3) App Perceptions: How users perceive Facetune.

What was done



We were interested in exploring the **differences** and **similarities** between **non-Facetune** users and **Facetune** users across different age groups. To do so, **6 separate surveys** were launched:

Non-FT users

- Gen Z (18-27) females
- Gen Z (18-27) males
- Millennials (27-45)
- Gen X (45-60)

*Use other editing apps such as VSCO, Tezza, Adobe Lightroom, Instagram's or TikTok's built-in tools and more.

FT & Faceapp users

- Gen Z (18-27)
- Millennials (27-45)
- Gen X (45-60)

*All females

What was done



Test N.	What was tested?	N. of users	Audience	Method	Test
1	What are Gen Z current behaviours and perceptions when it comes to vibe & aesthetics	234	Gen Z females (18-27), Non-FT users, U.S	Survey	Link
2	Comparison to Gen Z males	100	Gen Z males (18-27), Non-FT users, U.S	Survey	Link
3	Comparison to Millennials	102	Millennials females (27-45) Non-FT users, U.S	Survey	Link
4	Comparison to Gen X	100	Gen X females (45-60), Non-FT users, U.S	Survey	Link
5	Comparison to FT Millennials & Gen X	200	Aged 27-60 FT users, U.S: 134 Millennials 67 Gen X	Survey	Link
6	Comparison to FT Gen Z	100	Gen Z females (18-27), FT users, U.S	Survey	Link
7	Deeper understanding of what lighting means to users	20	10 Gen Z females (18-27), Non-FT users, U.S 10 Gen Z females (18-27), FT users, U.S	Unmoderated sessions	Link

835
Users

Main takeaways to remember

- **Lighting** is the #1 priority and most edited element **across all** age groups and for both Facetune and non-Facetune users.
- **Opportunity:** Invest in understanding how we can better serve both existing and new users around lighting needs.
- **Skin smoothing** is the **main differentiator** between Facetune and non-Facetune users, though the **gap is smaller for Gen Z** than for older groups.

Main Findings – 1st Stage

Comparing different age groups of non-FT users:

Gen Z (female & male), Millennials, Gen X

When asked, 'What makes a photo look good or aesthetic?' the top 3 elements were the same across all groups

Rank	Gen Z Female (n=234)	Gen Z Male (n=100)	Millennials (n=102)	Gen X (n=100)
#1	Lighting 70.9%	Lighting 79.0%	Lighting 79.4%	Lighting 74.0%
#2	Background 59.8%	Background 69.0%	Background 53.9%	Background 42.0%
#3	Camera Angle 49.6%	Camera Angle 48.0%	Camera Angle 49.0%	Camera Angle 40.0%
#4	Filters 41.9%	Outfit 44.0%	Facial Expression 26.5%	Facial Expression 33.0%

When asked, 'What aspects of a photo do you usually edit?' lighting was still universal

Rank	Gen Z Female (n=234)	Gen Z Male (n=100)	Millennials (n=102)	Gen X (n=100)
#1	Lighting/Color 69.5%	Lighting/Color 73.0%	Lighting/Color 85.3% ★	Lighting/Color 69.0%
#2	Adding Filters 44.6% (tied) ★	Photo ratio/ Cropping 52.0%	Photo ratio/ Cropping 60.8%	Photo ratio/ Cropping 55.0%
#3	Photo ratio/ Cropping 44.6% (tied)	Adding Filters 48.0% ★	Removing Objects 44.1%	Removing Objects 47.0%
#4	Removing Objects 33.9%	Removing Objects 40.0%	Adding Filters 42.2%	Adding Filters 36.0%
#5	Skin Smoothing 33.0%	Creative Effects 28.0% ★	Skin Smoothing 28.4%	Skin Smoothing 25.0%

Body reshaping and face adjustments ranked among the lowest priorities across all groups (non-FT users)

Element	Gen Z Female (n=234)	Gen Z Male (n=100)	Millennials (n=102)	Gen X (n=100)
Body reshaping	#9, 10.7%	#8, 14% (tied)	#10, 2.9%	#9, 8%
Face adjustments (e.g. eyes, jawline, nose)	#8, 18.5%	#9, 14% (tied)	#9, 6.9%	#8, 8%

Gen Z female users still show **some engagement with face adjustments**, though overall interest remains low compared to other elements.

Millennials and Gen X place **minimal emphasis on body or face edits** - suggesting potential category exhaustion among this group.

Main Findings – 2nd Stage

Comparing Facetune/FaceApp Users vs Non-Users
across all ages

Parallel surveys with Facetune & FaceApp users across all ages were launched to compare patterns and deepen our understanding.

When asking FT users, 'What makes a photo look good or aesthetic?'

Rank	Gen Z Female (n=100)	Millennials (n=134)	Gen X (n=100)
#1	Lighting 69%	Lighting 73.1%	Lighting 59.7%
#2	Background 43%	Background 44%	Facial Expression 47.8%
#3	Camera Angle 43%	Camera Angle 40.03%	Background 34.3%
#4	Outfit 31%	Facial Expression 33.6%	Camera Angle 32.8%

Lighting is #1 for all FT users, but Gen X uniquely prioritizes Facial Expression as #2

When asking FT users, 'What aspects of a photo do you usually edit?' lighting was still universal

Rank	Gen Z Female (n=100)	Millennials (n=134)	Gen X (n=100)
#1	Lighting/Color 76%	Lighting/Color 74.6%	Lighting/Color 74.6%
#2	Adding Filters 52% (tied)	Adding Filters 56% (tied)	Removing Objects 49.3%
#3	Photo ratio/ Cropping 52% (tied)	Skin Smoothing 56% (tied)	Photo ratio/ Cropping 49.3%
#4	Skin Smoothing 50%	Photo ratio/ Cropping 41.8%	Skin Smoothing 41.8%
#5	Removing Objects 45%	Removing Objects 41%	Adding Filters 38.8%

The core findings –

- **Lighting remained #1** priority and edited element for **Both FT and non-FT users**.
- However, **FT users** significantly prioritize **facial enhancement** and **skin smoothing** compared to non-FT users.

Millennials & Gen X

Comparing Facetune/FaceApp Users vs Non-Users

Millennials FT/FaceApp users put much more emphasis on beauty enhancements when editing their photos

2X

Skin smoothing usage

- **FT**: 56% vs **Non-FT**: 28% (Millennials)

***Largest absolute difference - the behavior that impacts the most people

4X

Face adjustments

- **FT**: 29% vs **Non-FT**: 7% (Millennials)

5X

Body reshaping

- **FT**: 16% vs **Non-FT**: 3% (Millennials)

***Highest multiplier - the behavior changes the most dramatically

What they actually edit?

Lighting ranks as the **most edited element** across all groups.

If we dive deeper, FT Millennials edit lighting less frequently than non-FT users.

Millennials

FT Users

74.6%

Non-FT Users

85.3%

-10.7 points

***A possible explanation might be that FT millennials, our core users, tend to focus on face and body edits, which may explain why lighting is lower for them, compared to non-FT users.

Skin smoothing is the single biggest behavioral difference between FT users and non FT-users

Millennials (Ages 27-45)

FT Users

56.0%

Non-FT Users

28.4%

+27.6

percentage points higher

Over half of FT Millennials use this feature regularly

Gen X (Ages 45-60)

FT Users

41.8%

Non-FT Users

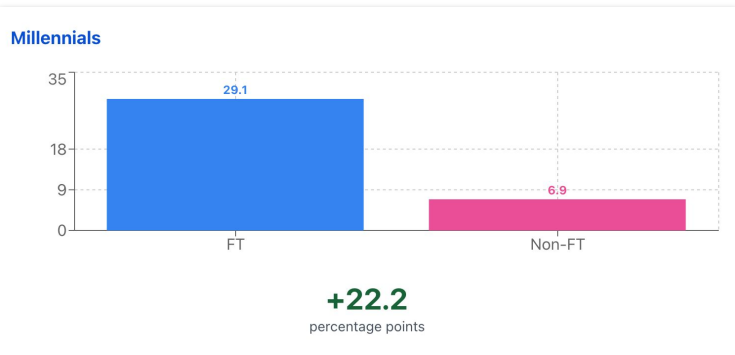
25.0%

+16.8

percentage points higher

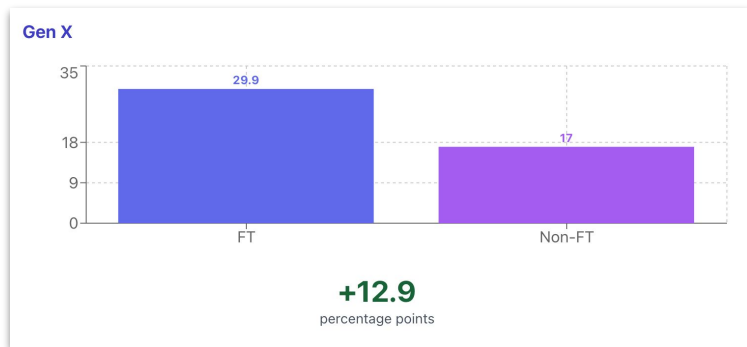
FT users are 3-4x more likely to adjust facial features

Face adjustments (eyes, jawline, nose) rank for what they edit jump significantly among FT users



Millennials show the most **significant increase** (from 7% to 29%).

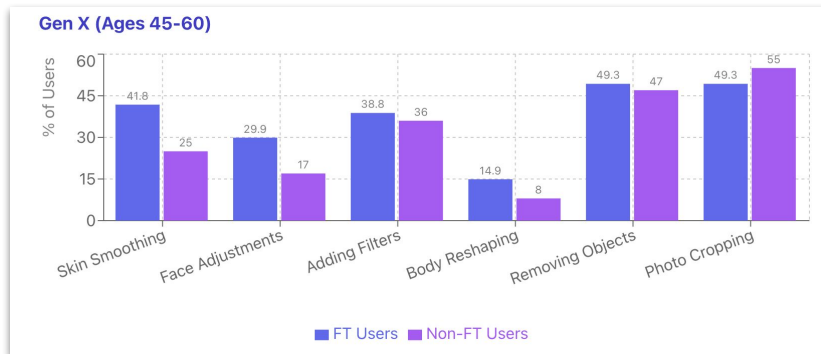
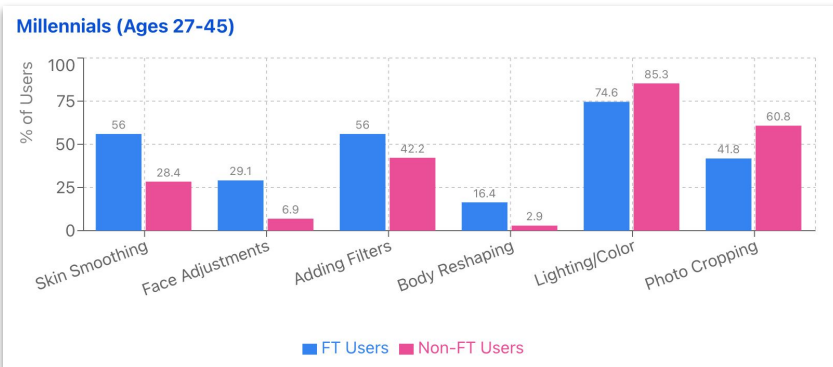
Among this group, FT users ranked it #6, while non-FT users ranked it #9.



Even among Gen X, face adjustments **nearly double** (17% → 30%)

FT users are higher in beauty enhancement categories

FT users are significantly higher in beauty enhancement categories, mainly in **skin smoothing** and **face adjustments**



Gen Z (females)

Comparing Facetune/FaceApp Users vs Non-Users

The core findings –

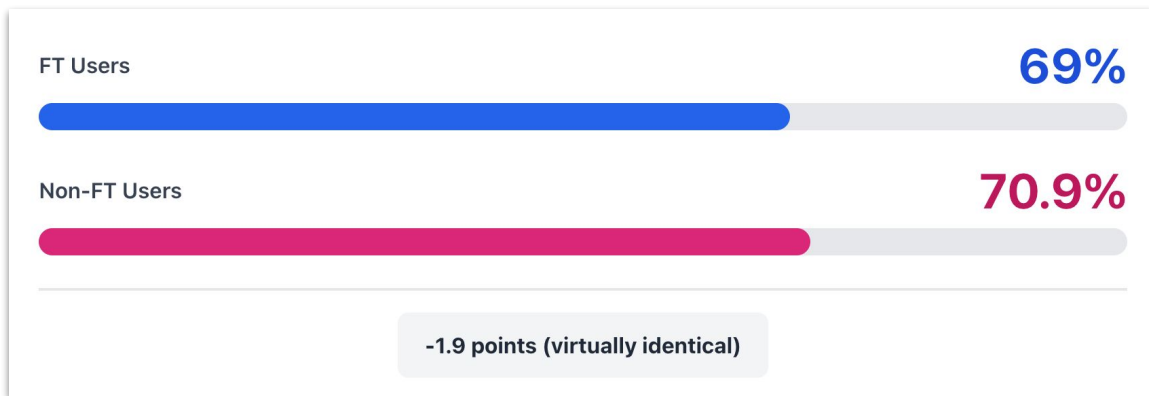
Unlike older FT users (Millennials especially) who showed 2–5X increases in beauty enhancement, Gen Z FT users show more moderate increases

The core findings –

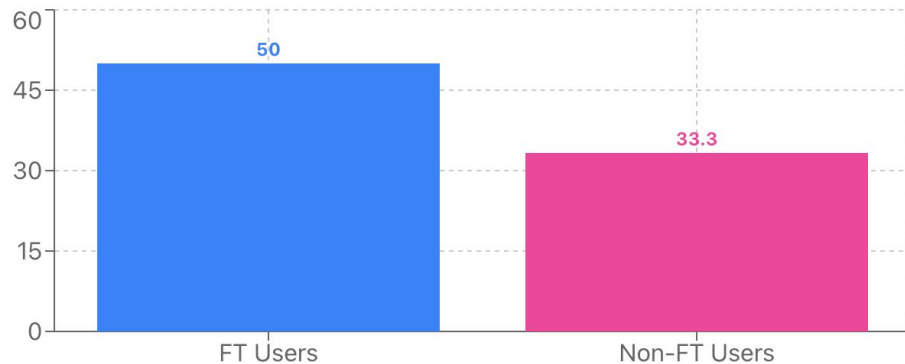
- Lighting is #1 for both FT and non-FT Gen Z users (~69%–71%)
- But FT Gen Z females show higher skin smoothing usage (+16.7 points) and face adjustments (+8.6 points)

Lighting priority **nearly identical** – Gen Z universally values lighting regardless of app choice

Unlike older generations, Gen Z maintains consistent lighting priority whether they use FT or not.



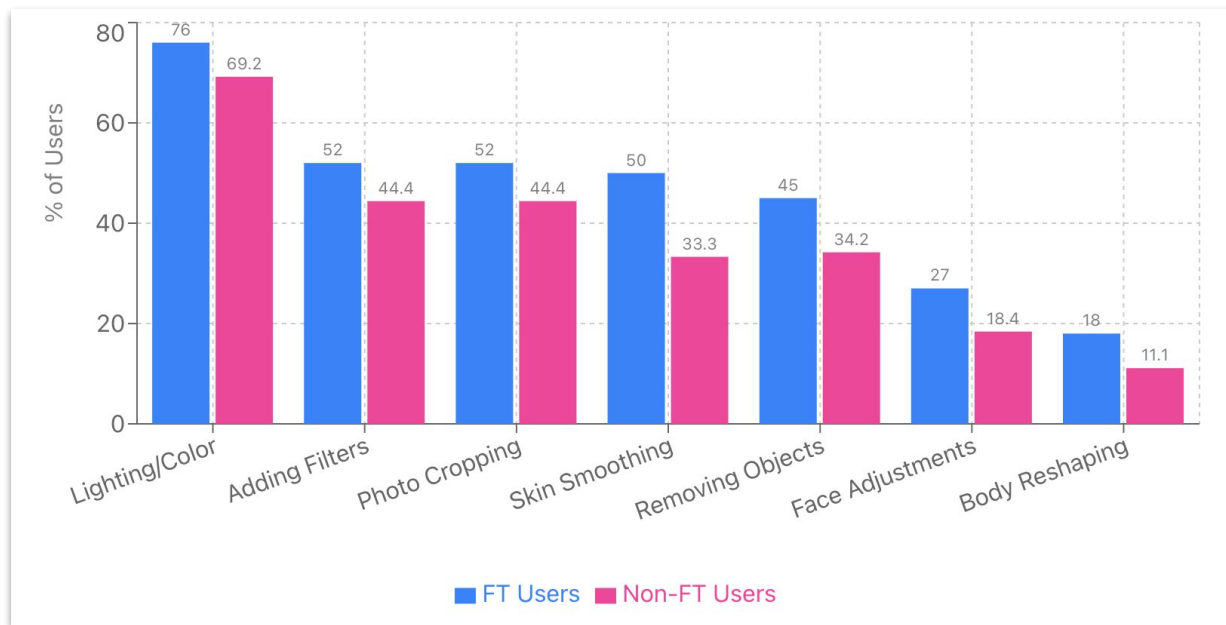
Gen Z FT users still lead in skin smoothing – the key differentiator between the groups



+16.7
percentage points higher

- 50% FT Gen Z vs 33.3% Non-FT Gen Z (+16.7 points)
- This means $\frac{1}{2}$ of FT users use skin smoothing vs $\frac{1}{3}$ of non-FT users
- While the gap is *smaller* than Millennials (+27.6 points, nearly 2X), it's still a **significant behavioral difference**

Gen Z shows more moderate gaps across all editing categories, unlike older users



The bottom line

- As expected, Facetune users are **more beauty and face focused**, but the **differences** between FT and non-FT users are **much larger among older users than within Gen Z**
- **Lighting consistently ranks as the #1 element** across all surveys, age groups, and app users.

This highlights the need to deepen our understanding of **what 'lighting' means to users** and **invest in solutions that address lighting needs** for both existing and new users.

So, what does lighting mean to users?

Unmoderated follow-up sessions

What was the goal of this research?

- 1) **Workflows:** How do users approach lighting editing? What apps/features do they use and for what types of photos?
- 2) **Motivations:** Why do they choose to edit lighting? What are they trying to achieve?
- 3) **Challenges:** What are their biggest frustrations when it comes to lighting – both in **taking** and **editing** photos?

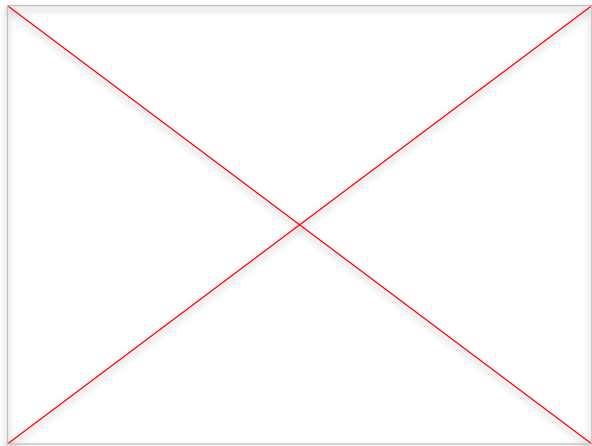
What was done?

- Unmoderated tests were conducted with **20** Gen Z participants – **both Facetune and non-Facetune** users who edit their photos and consider **lighting as the most important factor** for achieving a good, aesthetic image.
- Participants were asked to choose a photo they would **usually edit for lighting**, and to **demonstrate** their exact process, including the tools and adjustments they used.

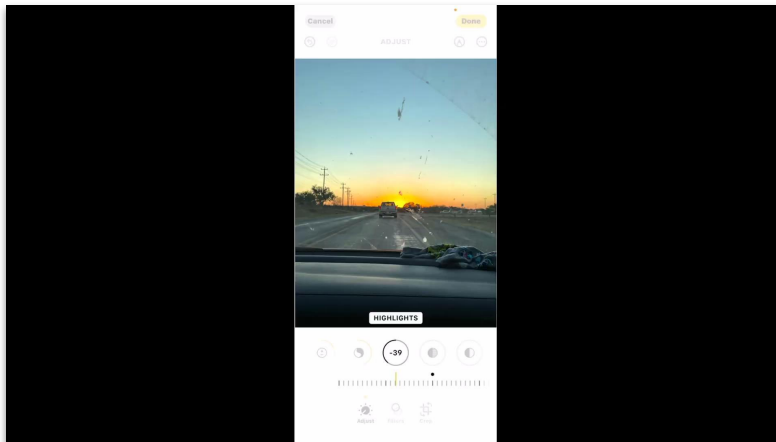
How do users approach lighting editing?

- Users mainly use the **adjust tools**, either on their iPhones or in an editing app such as VSCO, Adobe Lightroom, Picsart, Canva, Instagram built-in camera etc.
- Typically adopt a step-by-step, trial-and-error method, often starting with general auto adjustments before moving to detailed manual controls

How do users approach **lighting editing**?

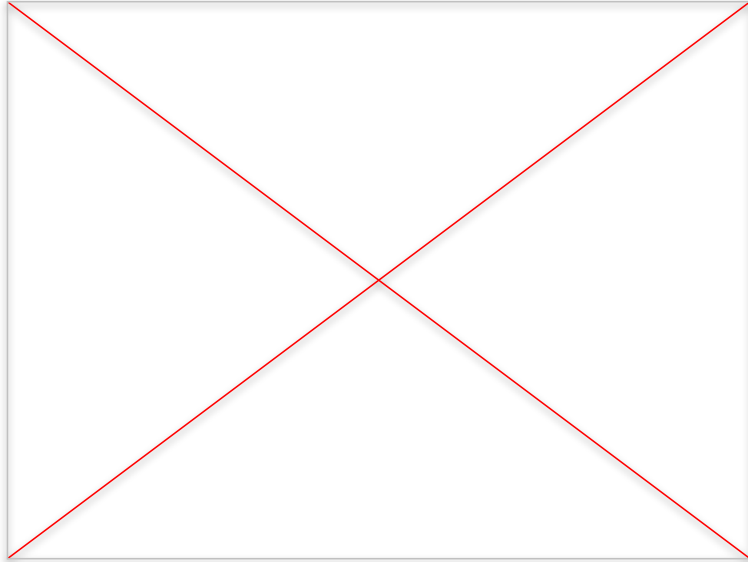


- Users think of “lighting” as the basic adjust controls



- Typically adopt a step-by-step, trial-and-error method

How do users approach lighting editing?



- Lighting editing is used to create a specific mood or vibe



- A minority of users use advanced lighting tools, such as separately adjusting the background or specific areas of the photo.

Which **tools** they use?

- Exposure
- Contrast
- Brightness
- Highlights
- Shadows
- Saturation
- Vibrance Warmth
- Temperature
- Tint
- Brilliance
- **Filters or presets**
- Subject & background separation (on Adobe lightroom & Canva)



Why do they choose to edit lighting?

Users choose to edit lighting primarily because the camera often **fails** to capture the scene as **it appears to the human eye**

Resulting in photos that **look too dark, flat,** or affected by unwanted **shadows** and **harsh contrasts.**



Specific reasons to edit lighting:

Correcting flaws & enhancing subject clarity:

- Fixing shadows and harsh light
- Improving subject visibility and definition – ensuring the subject (often themselves) stands out and well lit
- Addressing unflattering elements – like hiding signs of fatigue, such as dark circles under the eyes
- Balancing skin tones – using saturation or temperature

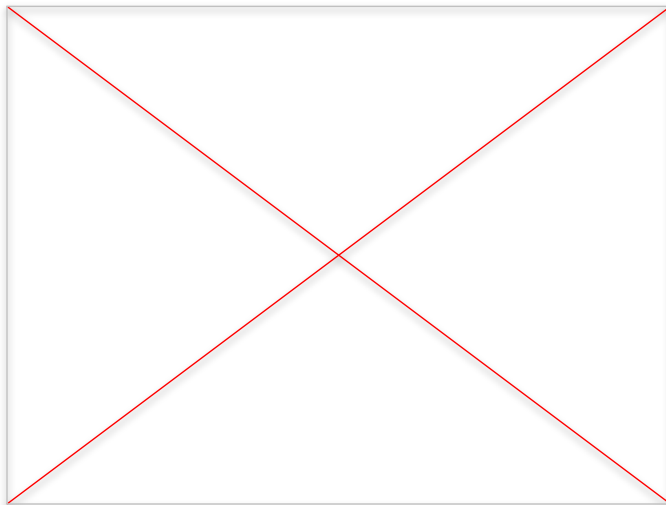
Achieving a desired aesthetic & vibe:

- Lighting editing is used to create a specific mood, quality, or color representation that was missing from the original capture.
- Users aim for the photo to look 'high quality' and vibrant
- Some edit to match a specific aesthetic, such as a slightly darker, "moodier" look

The most annoying or frustrating parts of lighting when taking photos fall into 3 primary reoccurring themes

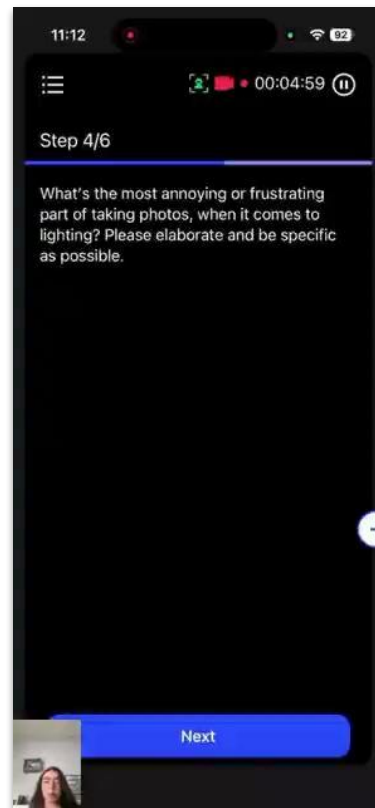
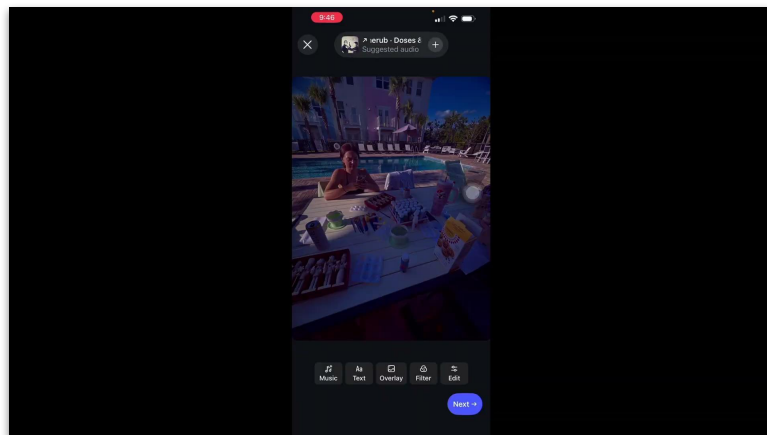
1

Cameras rarely capture scenes as they truly appear, resulting in images that don't match what users saw



2

**Unwanted
shadows and
glare can ruin a
photo and make
you look less
flattering**



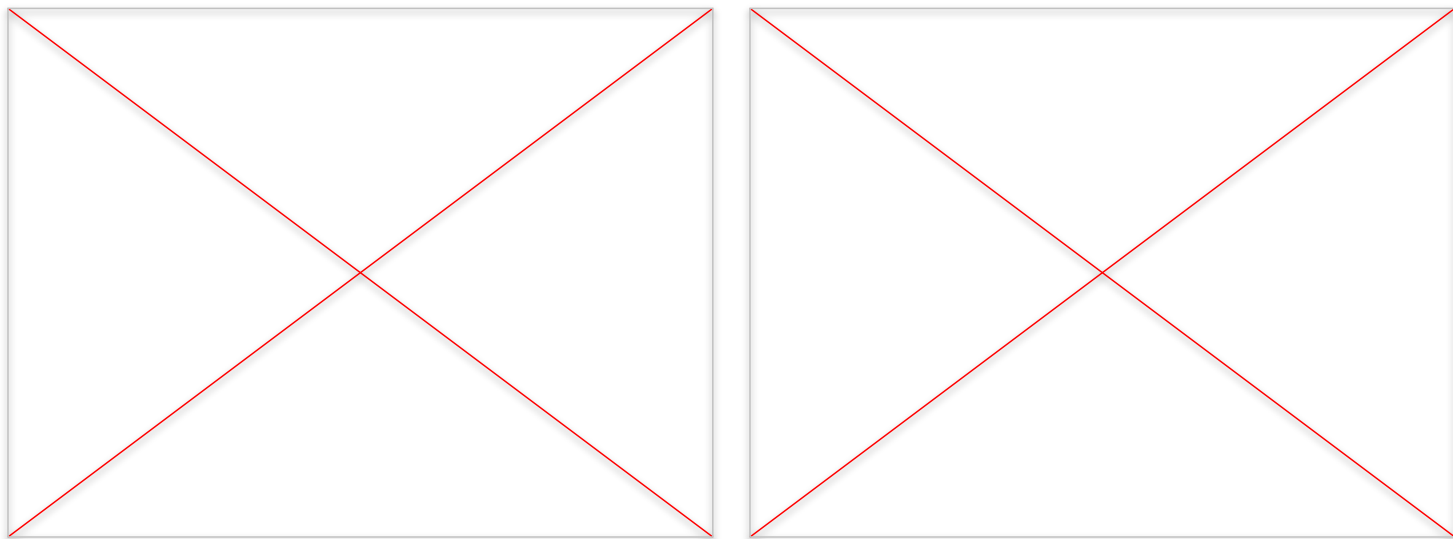
3

Users struggle to capture balanced lighting, as scenes are often either too dark or overly bright, washing out details

The most annoying or frustrating parts of lighting when editing photos fall into 3 primary reoccurring themes

1

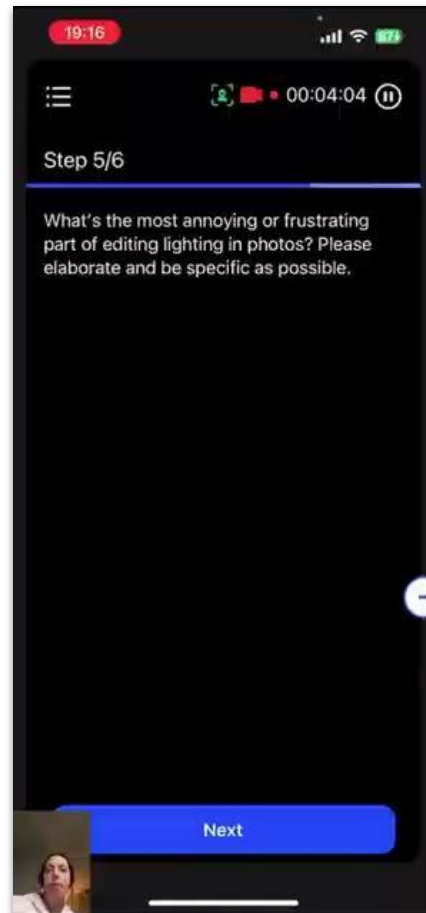
Users struggle to improve lighting without crossing the line into an obviously edited or unnatural look



2

Users know which lighting issues they want to fix, but because most lighting tools only offer broad, global edits, they're left without a simple way to achieve the result they need

- Especially frustrating when dealing with **shadows** or trying to adjust lighting on **specific areas** of the photo, like parts of the face or background.



3

Because users don't know which lighting tools to use, they end up in a confusing, and time-consuming trial-and-error process



Recs & Next Steps

Recs & Next Steps

To really understand Gen Z's editing and sharing behavior, we need to dive deeper into their real priorities and motivations. This includes exploring:

- How they approach key elements like **lighting, background, camera angle, crop** and **filters**
- Their current editing workflows and **decision-making process**
- Their inspirations, interests, and aesthetics when creating and sharing content

These gaps require richer qualitative insight – therefore, **in-depth interviews will be conducted** to uncover the nuances behind their behaviors and needs.

Recs & Next Steps

We should approach **lighting** through 3 complementary directions:

**Replace the existing
lighting feature with a
new version**

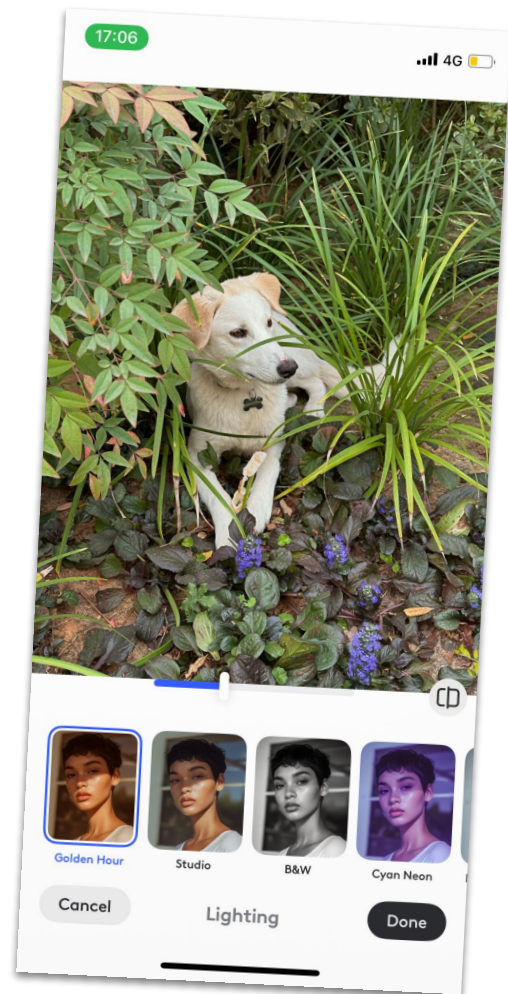
**Organizing editor tools
into a unified lighting
framework**

**Create a new lighting
experience to address
user pain points**

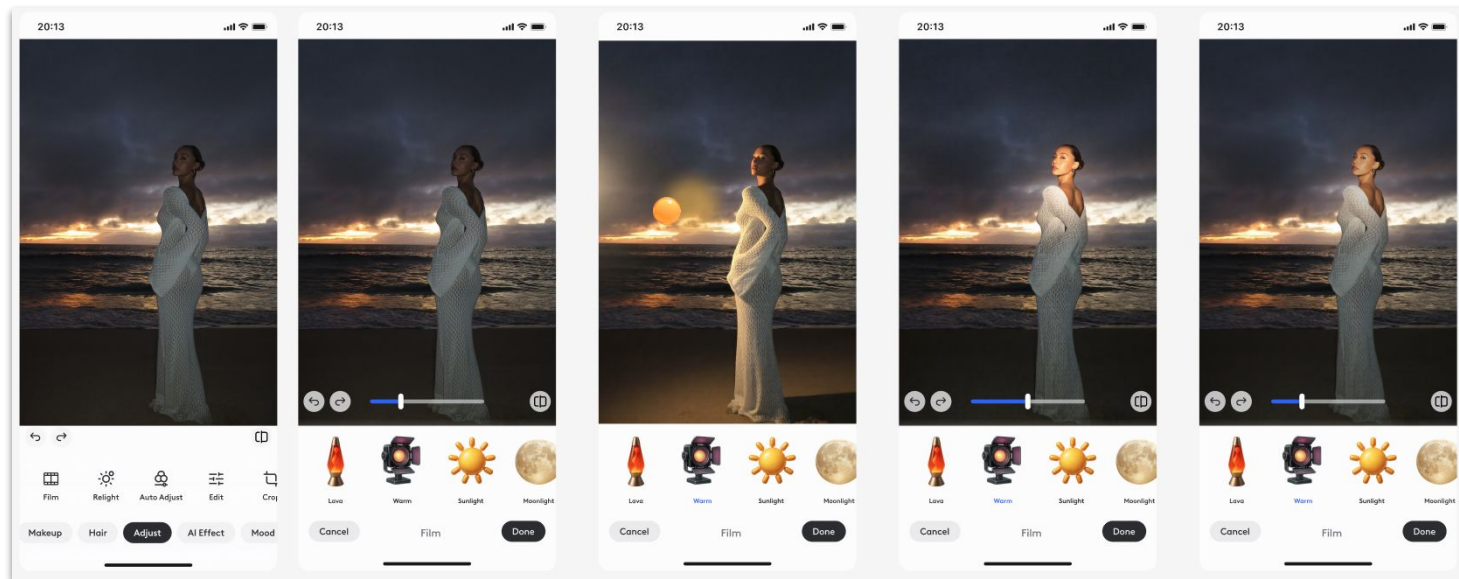
Recs & Next Steps

- 1) Replace the existing lighting feature with a new version

A new version that offers enhanced, more precise, area-specific adjustments and a more innovative overall experience.



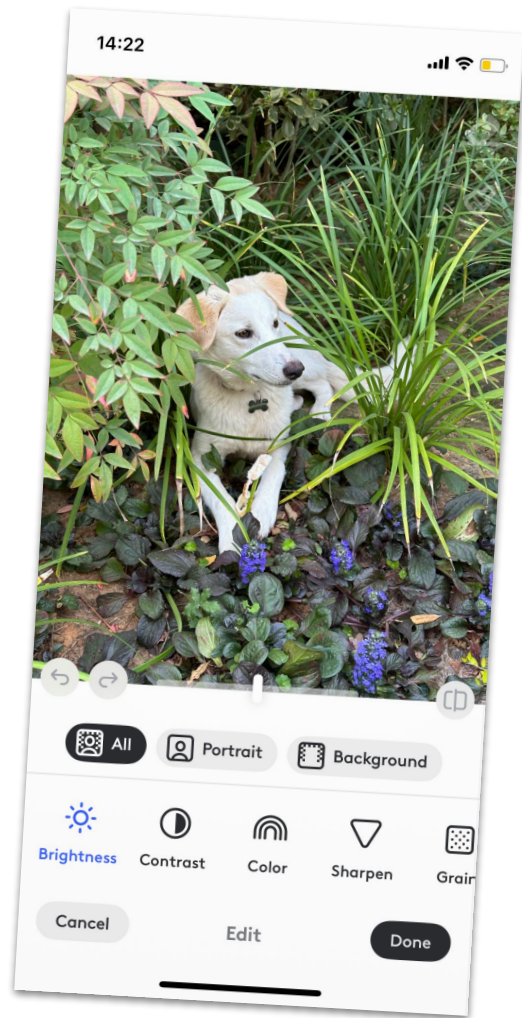
Recs & Next Steps



Recs & Next Steps

2) Organizing editor tools into a unified lighting framework

- Gather all **relevant existing and new editor tools** under a dedicated **'Lighting' space** to create a more cohesive and intuitive user experience.
- Research and **benchmark competitors** (VSCO, Lightroom, PicsArt, etc.) to elevate our filters, presets, and subject-background separation.



Recs & Next Steps

3) Create a new lighting experience to address user pain points

(with Qwen or Nano banana)

- Tackle core pain points in photo capture – especially dark, flat images that **don't reflect what users saw**.
- Help users achieve results they **can't reach on their own today** – like removing unwanted shadows and creating more flattering, well-lit photos.
- Empower users to **easily reach balanced, natural lighting** – replicating the **golden hour look** that's often hard to achieve in real life.

